Aiden McBroom

ULTRA

Word Count: 3,458

ULTRA is Aiden McBroom's sophomore portfolio. It is written in eight parts, and includes the following pieces:

1. **ouroboroi projection**
    a. *A dialogue between two lovers fighting for control.*
2. **STRIKEOUT**
    a. *A narrative about the initial meeting between lovers that spirals out of control.*
3. **a drawer in cambridge**
    a. *A nonlinear plea for observation, noticing, and care.*
4. **scene: aiden is casually cruel and does not care**
    a. *An apathetic exchange between two lovers.*
5. **FIN**
    a. *The final narrative iteration on a flawed, doomed relationship.*
6. **gamma, sine, geometry**
    a. *A poem about obsession, boundaries, and the cost of losing control.*
7. **vivisection**
    a. *A direct address to you, the reader.*
8. **tender**
    a. *An artifact from the man I once was.*

Writer's Statement

This portfolio is my metabolism of fourteen months of relationship, control, and mistakes. It chronicles the relationship between Aiden and Violet across about a year and a half. Aiden is characterized by narcissism, manipulation, and obsession. Violet is characterized by naivety, compassion, and attachment.

ouroboroi projection is the preluding poem that examines the relationship in retrospect. Written as a dialogue between two voices, it confronts what happens when attempting to reignite a toxic relationship.

STRIKEOUT is a narrative that recounts the story of how Aiden and Violet first met under bowling alley lights, and the coming reckoning that would stem from impulse.

a drawer in cambridge and *scene: aiden is casually cruel and does not care* are companion pieces that dissect the same dynamic from opposite angles. *words* surrenders Aiden's narrative authority entirely, granting Violet the voice he denied her in life. *scene* restores it — but weaponizes it, exposing the machinery behind Aiden's charm by placing his interior monologue beside his performance in real time.

FIN is a final narrative detailing the ultimate fallout between Aiden and Violet, tracing the relationship's collapse through a series of confrontations that strip away whatever tenderness remained. It is written in third person because Aiden can no longer afford to say I.

gamma, sine, geometry is a poem set in the classroom they shared, where proximity became its own form of violence. It documents the aftermath—what obsession looks like when it has nowhere left to go but observation.

vivisection and *tender* close the portfolio by turning outward. *vivisection* addresses the reader directly, interrogating whether confession can ever be trusted from someone who has already proven themselves a liar. *tender* answers that question with an artifact—a text exchange that required no literary framing because it didn't need any. It is the only piece in this portfolio that I did not design. It simply happened.

ULTRA is named for ultraviolet light—the wavelength just beyond what the human eye can perceive. This portfolio operates in that register: the parts of a relationship that are felt but never fully seen, the damage that doesn't surface until long after exposure. It is not an apology. Apologies are for the people you hurt, not for an audience. It is, instead, the most honest thing I have ever written.

Which, as *vivisection* warns you, may not mean much coming from me.

Aiden McBroom

ouroboroi projection

Word Count: 117

you and i are alike.

i call us entwined,

and sentence us to an eternity alone.

you cannot escape me.

no, aiden.

we're not.

we never were.

choke on your own tail.

refusal?

bold..

you always come back.

return to me.

do you think i'm joking?

we are finished.

forever.

please just accept that.

and leave me to feast on myself?

gladly. it was better than you anyways.

still, we will remain friends.

right?

absolutely. not.

you fucking narcissist.

you ruined me.

i hate you.

the sparrow finds her voice.

i will clip your wings

and steal your song.

i know every hair on your head.

you don’t control me.

not anymore.

it’s over.

enjoy your life.

Aiden McBroom

STRIKEOUT

Word Count: 1,253

“If I throw one more gutter ball, I am going to lose my mind!” you say, rolling your eyes. Your bowling ball is, for the second time in a row, helplessly drifting off the edge of the lane.

“Thought you already did, the way you’re throwing,” she says, so certain it stings. You both laugh and look at each other for two more seconds than you both should’ve.

You focus on your embarrassing bowling skills instead.

Yet, as you approach your chair, you see her glancing at you. Again. She watches the scoreboard, and notices your hair. You change the music, and notice her eyes.

You and Violet do this several times.

That was the pattern of the night—two people pretending not to notice each other in a bowling alley. The game didn’t matter anymore; what is she doing—that is the question you already know the answer to but need to confirm.

By the end of a round that banished you to the peanut gallery, you were taking down numbers to plan another hangout.

The way she left a heart by her name was not lost on you.

You walked outside to feel the autumn breeze hit your skin and her hand brushes yours beside the railing. Her Mom’s car is almost as small as she is, and you smirk as she flashes her brights at you for sticking your tongue out.

“No one’s good at everything, Vi,” you said, sneaking a nickname and testing the waters.

“Says the boy who just got last place,” she laughed. But you noticed her pause beforehand—the way her face lifted slightly as she heard that name.

Weeks later, after you have both fallen for each other, you linger near the couch. All the others have left, and you two are left alone in her living room.

This couch, conveniently, is not big enough to seat two people lying down. As you watch television, her cheek begins to nuzzle your neck.

You do not move.

Her eyes meet yours. For a moment, you understand her.

At once, a young child—carefree and content. Another, a teenager hiding from herself—insecure and lonely.

But at this moment, she is simply Violet. And that is enough for you.

You lay down. She does too. As she's laying on your chest, you notice her perfume for the first time. She breathes in. You hold her tight.

As you guide her chin towards yours, your Mom's headlights shine through the window.

"Just really good friends, right?" you say, longing for more.

In this moment Violet first loves you. Her eyes follow you down the patio and across the lawn. In them is care without measure.

You will never cuddle on the couch again.

Your throat tightens as you turn the key. At 1:00 A.M., the world is quiet, but your Mom's van carries on the same. Outside, the stars are hidden by clouds. It is foggy and you struggle to see.

But it does not matter. You have waited for this—yearned for this—for weeks. No weather will get in between you and impulse tonight.

Violet already warned you it's a bad idea. "Too risky," she says. You see the panic flash across the screen even after you reassure her that you both won't get caught. Deep down, you know she's right.

But the possibility is too enticing.

You will be the first boy she ever kisses. You are the only boy she has ever liked. That fact makes you feel good, even if you never admit it.

As you pull away from your driveway, you relax—nobody stormed out looking for you. You cruise down the road, watching your speed.

You pass by your high school, and your chest lifts. Suddenly, you are overcome with nostalgia. You remember your first girlfriend—Ashlin—and chuckle. You remember kissing her for the first time underneath the trees. Everybody from History class saw it. After that, you didn't pay much attention to her. She broke up with you.

It didn't matter.

You remember Harper, too. You just broke up with her for Violet. Guilt washes over you—she was the first woman you ever slept with. And now you're using what you learned on another girl.

Oh well—she'll get back with you if you ask. You always had a talent for wrapping women around your finger. You keep that in mind as you pull over beside Violet's house.

"I'm here," you text as you pop a mint.

You watch her emerge from behind her home, crouching along the wall in a Harvard sweatshirt that is comically large on her. Your headlights illuminate her as she approaches your passenger seat.

As she sits down, you smoothly crank the music up. John Mayer riffs on his electric guitar as she climbs into your backseat, and you catch a whiff of her perfume on her back.

It is sweetly bitter.

You cup her face as she sits on your lap. She looks apprehensive—too small in her sweater—as she gazes into your eyes. You are unsure what she sees.

Your lips graze hers. She closes her eyes, and begins to kiss you. Hesitantly, at first. But she finds her confidence and gets faster. She grinds her hips on your lap, and your hands trail down her sides toward her chest.

She freezes.

Her eyes are scared.

She's no Harper, after all.

But as you two make out in your backseat, your headlights shine into her Mom's room. Brightly. She rises from her bed, anxious to know who's outside her room at 1:30 A.M.

Violet’s phone buzzes once. She ignores it.

Twice. She checks it.

“Inside. Now.”

———

It is a crisp autumn night at the end of October. Your hands freeze in the sharp wind, but you hold your tongue. Violet reaches her hand behind her, calling you closer. She entwines her fingers in yours, and you begin to warm.

Her father walks ahead of her, glancing back occasionally. You suppose sneaking his daughter out didn’t make him very trusting.

You sit on the edge of a wooden overlook with your friend, his girlfriend, Violet, and her father. Your friend cracks jokes with Violet’s father, joking about action movies you’ve never seen. Your cheeks begin to redden. No warmth can cool them.

Violet glances at you and rests her hand on your shoulder. You lean over and steal a kiss. She smiles at you. The marching bands blare their horns. The stars peak out from beyond the clouds. It is cold, wet, and you wouldn't be anywhere else.

You are happy. Violet is happy, too.

You remember her father’s stories—of surviving holiness camps and a fundamentalist family. He showed you more grace than any altar ever did. Instead of forbidding you and Violet, he shook your hand and told you to learn your lesson.

You smile because you believe he is Harper in fifteen years. You made the right call.

———

You assured her you both wouldn't get caught again. "Unlikely," you said. "As long as you stick to the plan, we will be fine. Stop stressing."

She nods along, but you see her eyebrows furrowing.

She walks into her Mom's room to return something. She is caught again.

It is 1:47 A.M. You have sped down the highway at over one hundred miles per hour. You open your phone to see a single message.

abort. caught

You type.

you are so fucking incompetent. how could you be this stupid?

You feel like a man.

You hit send.

Are you?

Aiden McBroom

a drawer in cambridge

Word count: 447

you always looked good in the brown corduroy jacket. you held me tightly on your chest and ,for the first time, i trusted somebody. i held nothing back, aiden. i told you things i'd never said out loud, and you listened so tenderly. you care for me in such a unique way. i don't know what we were on that couch tonight, but we weren't friends like you tried to make it seem. i can't let us just sit like that. i've given you too much to hold onto for that.

you're so warm on the phone. you tell me things about myself i nearly believe. but part of me can't. i think it's my insecurity. i love you, i think. but i don't trust you enough to let you all the way in. i give you a mask, but you're too self-absorbed to catch it. you make me feel safe, but i'm acting for you. still, i know that i want you to take me somewhere special.

———

why are you pushing this onto me? you knew i was uncomfortable with it, but i didn't know how to say no. i tried to tell you without telling you—didn't you catch my eyes? you're always so attentive—you notice every detail about me. but when it comes between me and you, you choose yourself. you always do.

i want tenderness. and i only get it whenever i fit your image. but at the same time, i crave your approval. to my detriment. against my wishes. i need your validation, aiden. i trusted you with my first real romantic moment, and you went for my chest. i needed you to not even try it—i shouldn't have to ask not to. am i just a tally mark to you?

———

you are cruel, aiden. i don't know what my footsteps meant to you, but i needed reassurance in that moment. i sobbed into my mother's arms because i was so hurt by you.

you and your pride. you think your intellect saves you, but apparently you never learned to treat people well. why can't you understand that i'm doing all of this for you? i see something in us i've never seen before. just treat me like a person instead of a ledger line. please.

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i saw you on the news last night. i wonder where my harvard sweatshirt is now. i'm so proud of you. and i'm so unsurprised. it hurt in a weird way, because i know you never threw it away. you're sentimental like that.

it's gonna end up in some drawer in cambridge because you'll never get over me. not really. i will be your love lost, aiden.

Aiden McBroom

scene: aiden is casually cruel and does not care

Word count: 360

AIDEN: *God, I hope that I don't mess this up. Last chance man—play your cards right and you might just save this. There is no fucking way I pull this off. You can't possibly be this stupid, right?*

AIDEN: hey

VIOLET: *why is he texting me? shouldn't he be dating my best friend right now?*

VIOLET: hi

AIDEN: *Holy shit. She actually replied. She's still soft for me. Tiffany is too, probably. Good to know I have options.*

AIDEN: i know we haven't talked much since tiffany and i stated dating. but i just wanted to say i'm sorry for how everything played out. you don't have to reply to this if you don't want to, but i felt like it needed to be said.

VIOLET: what are you even sorry about?

AIDEN: for taking your best friend away from you. it's fine if i go, but i took support away from you. i hate watching you crumble violet, even if you don't believe that

VIOLET: then why don't you act like it?

AIDEN: because i'm impulsive. you know that. i did it when i snuck you out and i did it with tiffany. but i've been thinking about you more lately and i want to show you that i've changed. i'm willing to fight for us vi. i always have been.

VIOLET: aiden, i want to believe you. i've heard so much about tiffany, and honestly, i'm more upset with her than with you. she should've never gone for you in the first place; you were just taking available options. i know you didn't mean to hurt me. i just got caught in the crossfire.

AIDEN: there it is violet. you understand it. but you also shouldn't have to deal with that alone. but i'm not sure if i'm the right call for that. i still want you, but ultimately, i want what's best for you. with or without me.

AIDEN: *Oh my God, I think she's buying it. Just don't ask questions.*

VIOLET: aiden, i have to ask you something.

AIDEN: yes, vi?

VIOLET: how long ago did you and tiffany break up?

AIDEN: about eight hours ago.

Aiden McBroom

FIN

Word count: 872

Aiden's SUV is parked beside trees a block away. He turns his headlights off as soon as he turns down her block.

Aiden walks down the road and peers into her living room. The lights are off, the cars are parked. But the house breathes differently. The weight of anticipation is lighter now, but it is still there.

Aiden's stepstool hits the gravel below her window, settling into an indent long set and long earned. Violet opens her window, and he crawls through. His shoes fall off outside as he swings his torso through.

He does the same things he always does: he removes his remaining shoe, closes her window, and kisses her forehead. Violet is nervous but is happy Aiden is here.

He sits down on her bed and lays down. She gets on top of him, and lays on his chest. They cuddle as her sitcom drones in the background. He knows it well now—the one she knows each scene of and tells him about vigorously.

He wonders if he perceives her the same.

Tactfully as always, he begins to kiss her. His lips trace every curve of her face—every detail—before moving down her neck. She is breathing heavily now, but she is no longer apprehensive. She wants this—at least she believes she does.

Aiden takes off Violet's shirt. She smiles at him, and continues to kiss him. Whoever Violet was in Aiden's backseat, she is no longer that girl.

He observes her undressing. He is pleased.

But he will not let her touch him.

———

Aiden is on the phone with Violet. They are talking about their days. Violet had a long day in band class. Aiden is having a relaxing evening.

Ping.

ABBY: Hey, I heard some more people talking about you luring Violet outside her home. Just thought you'd wanna know.

"Hey Vi, do you mind explaining what my sister just texted me?"

Aiden shares his screen with Violet. Her stomach drops.

"Just my Mom spreading more rumors babe. I never talked about that evening, like you asked me not to."

AIDEN: Who'd you hear it from?

ABBY: Violet. Who else?

Aiden feels his heart drop. Who has she told?

"Violet, my sister wouldn't lie. What's going on?"

"I don't know what she's talking about, but it didn't come from me."

AIDEN: Violet is insistent. Are you sure?

ABBY: I'm telling you the truth, Aiden. Why would I lie to you?

"Be honest with me, Vi. Have you spoken about that night to other people?"

“Yes.”

Violet sobs over the phone. Aiden recognizes her mask. That is whom he has loved.

He knows it is all he will ever love.

_____

Hazel jokes about Aiden after tennis.

He constructs a monument of literature around her.

Aiden sends it to her.

Hazel reads it, horrified.

And intrigued.

Hazel is fascinated by Aiden. Aiden is fascinated by Hazel.

Never their bodies. Only their minds.

_____

Aiden returns from church. He is in the backseat with his sister, Abby.

Another text from Hazel pings his phone. He barely notices it.

“Who’s that?” Abby asks, concerned. She knows his patterns—who he is to Violet.

“A friend. Why?” he says, matter-of-factly.

“A friend? Sure. How would Violet feel about her?” she asks, raising her eyebrows.

“She’ll stay with me no matter what I do or who I text. Cheat, lie, hurt—it doesn’t matter, Abby. I have her wrapped around my finger,” he says.

Aiden continues playing on his phone. Abby is sick to her stomach.

_____

Aiden and Violet are on the phone. They have just finished in the bathroom.

“I think I hear my Mom. Be quiet, let me call you back,” Violet says, certain.

But Aiden doesn’t hear back from Violet that evening. Or the next day. He texts her about how happy he is with her, how content she makes him feel. He is nervous, but confident she will come back this evening.

She does come back. Claiming they need to talk.

“Who’s Hazel?”

_____

“I was just joking. She’s exaggerating,” Aiden says as Violet sobs in his front seat. He looks at her—the way the sun bounces off her tear-soaked face—and smiles softly.

Violet shows him the text. The indictment. He is unsure how to feel.

“You realize this is it, right? It’s really over now” she says, choking on her words.

“Don’t say that, Vi. We’ll figure it out—we always do,” Aiden says, dismissive.

“No, Aiden. It’s really over. After I walk out, there are no redos. My Mom won’t allow it.”

“And since when have we listened to her? Let’s cool it for a few weeks, see other people, and then revisit. How does that sound?” Aiden says, bargaining.

“It hurts. I can’t keep doing this. Just text me later—we’ll figure this out after school.”

———

AIDEN: I see you for who you are. You’ve lied, deceived, and double-crossed me this entire relationship. I don’t love you; I love the mask you put on. But that isn’t the real you, is it? You could never be authentic with me, and this is the consequence. Goodbye, Violet.

VIOLET: If that’s how you need me to be, then that’s okay. But I loved you. I really did. I am not some cartoon villain, Aiden.

Aiden McBroom

gamma, sine, geometry

Word count: 197

My chest aches for what I almost had

Over and over, I see lives I may have lived.

But you remain out of reach.

Painfully beyond my hands.

It is Geometry. It is fourth hour.

I am sitting in my usual spot by your desk, waiting for you to walk in.

I swear I feel my heart rising out of my throat.

What do you think of me?

You enter the room, avoiding my eyes.

You focus on the wall. It has never been more interesting.

I watch you.

You notice it. I know you do.

I had this coming

I never thought you'd burn me though.

You sit at your desk, and focus on the lesson.

Was I nothing to you, Vi?

You're protecting yourself.

I know you're fragile.

That's why I held you tenderly.

It's time for you to move on.

But I don't take things lightly.

I'll reach out again. I'll orbit you, observing.

Not maliciously.

Just satisfied.

Happy with the woman you're becoming.

Pleased with your growth.

Glad you're thriving.

And knowing I played some small part.

The bell rings.

You grab your phone.

I walk behind you.

You do not look back.

Aiden McBroom

vivisection

Word count: 143

Dear reader,

After thousands of words of prose, poetry, and melodramatic confessionals about two immature teenagers, you believe you understand me. I have been plain in my self-description because I believe you deserve a glimpse into what drives me—especially those whom I've hurt.

You are also wondering why I am addressing you directly. "Isn't this supposed to be about Aiden and Violet," you think. But, reader, the truth is that I write for you, not myself. The cinematics, the theatrics—they have all been designed with your perception in mind.

If you believe I'm arrogant and simple, let me ask you one thing: how do you know I'm telling you the truth?

It's not like I'm foreign to deception—I've lied, cheated, and stolen my way through many different people. Who are you to believe that you are the exception?

And you think I'm prideful.

Aiden McBroom

tender

Word count: 69

DECEMBER 25TH, 2025. 12:06 P.M.

AIDEN: merry christmas vi. been reflecting on this year, and i'm very grateful for everything we've shared—good and bad. hope you've been healing and finding all the love, joy, and peace you deserve. no need to respond; just know i'm never a stranger for you

VIOLET: *who is this*

AIDEN: aiden

VIOLET: *thanks, merry christmas*

AIDEN: you as well. take care vi